



IN CONTEXT

GENRE

French fantasy

DIRECTOR

Jean Cocteau

WRITER

Jean Cocteau

STARS

Jean Marais, Josette Day

BEFORE

1902 Georges Méliès's *A Trip to the Moon* is an early special-effects fantasy movie.

1930 *The Blood of a Poet*, Cocteau's first movie, explores the power of visual metaphors.

1933 *King Kong* portrays a sympathetic relationship between a beast and a girl.

AFTER

1950 *Orphée* is the second of Cocteau's movies about the Greek legend of Orpheus.

1991 Disney's *Beauty and the Beast* is one of the company's most successful movies.

CHILDREN BELIEVE WHAT WE TELL THEM

LA BELLE ET LA BÊTE / 1946

For some critics, Jean Cocteau's *La Belle et la Bête* (*Beauty and the Beast*) is one of the most poetic movies ever made. It is the story of a young girl (Josette Day) trapped in the palace of a beastly creature (Jean Marais). Though repelled by the beast at first, the girl can see the goodness within him and falls in love with him. Cocteau tells the tale with such serious honesty that it is elevated from bedtime story into something morally profound.

For almost 40 years before he made *La Belle et la Bête*, Cocteau was a poet, and poetry had been the theme of his first, 55-minute experimental movie in 1930, *The Blood of a Poet*, about the mythical poet Orpheus. Cocteau was eager to deny that there was any symbolism in *La Belle et la Bête*, which was his first full-length feature movie, although he also believed that poetry was an unconscious process. Contemporary US critic Bosley Crowther was struck by the movie's "gorgeous visual metaphors." At the same time, it is striking how plainly the story is told.

Supernatural simplicity

Tellingly, the movie opens not with the story, but with Cocteau writing on a school blackboard. He is making it clear that this is a story with a moral lesson, not a fantasy to be indulged in. "Children believe what we tell them," he writes.

On the movie's release, critics praised its exquisite and imaginative costumes, designed by Christian Bérard.

